

vides them exposure to every aspect of running a telecom organisation. Some companies continuously invest in imparting new skills and education to their employees to keep them abreast with the latest in the industry.

There is money too

The engineers in telecom sector get packages depending upon the nature of their job, type of organisation and industry environment.

Sinha explains, "There are many segments within the telecom world. One is a vendor company, another is an OEM company and then there is a service provider company. So they all have different kinds of pay packages to offer. For a fresher, the package may vary dramatically from as low as Rs 100,000 per annum to as high as about Rs 500,000-600,000 per annum. It depends upon the location, the type of company and the type of job you are doing."

"The telecom world is also penetrated by the IT world. So there are other people also who can get into these jobs. There is enough competition, but there is no limit of financial growth for the right kind of people," he adds.

How to begin?

The industry hires people from various engineering and management disciplines. For example, a telecom infrastructure provider (tower company) would need engineers from disciplines such as electrical, civil and mechanical. However, the bulk of technical requirements for the active telecom infrastructure are fulfilled by electronics and communications engineers, who work on a large number of electronic elements that form part of a telecom network.

Usually, these engineers know the basics of telecommunications engineering. But, they can be groomed further to specialise in individual job functions through on-the-job training or through some focused vocational training provided by institutions like Cognitel.

With technology shifting towards an all-IP network and the growing

need for mobile applications, you need to look for ways to complement your existing curriculum with courses in new technologies like advanced data networking and applications development. These can be explored as electives if offered within the same institute or as a specialised training outside.

Last but not the least is the requirement for managerial talent. There are a few MBA schools offering specialised courses in telecom management, which can be considered as a starting point for those keen to join the industry in managerial cadre.

Where are the jobs?

There are immense options for freshers. If you have an understanding of how the telecom industry works and broad-level experience, the horizon gets broader for you.

You can work for:

1. Telecom operators such as Bharti Airtel, Idea Cellular and Vodafone
2. Telecom equipment manufacturers such as Nokia Siemens Networks, Huawei, Ericsson and Cisco
4. Passive infrastructure providers such as Indus Towers, Viom Networks and Bharti Infratel
5. Value-added services companies such as OnMobile, Comviva Technologies and Hungama
6. Service vendors such as GTL and Innovis
7. Network operation and management companies such as Colt Technologies
8. System integrators such as Accenture, IBM and Tech Mahindra

Growth prospects

You can typically join the industry as a graduate engineer trainee. Thereafter, you can move to many different roles including project/operations management, product technical support, network management, solution architect and R&D engineer. There is also scope for rotation across these areas.

Job profiles

The following are broad functional requirements in the industry:

1. Network planning and optimisation. This involves designing a telecom network with the use of industry-standard tools, maps and processes. It also includes a regular benchmarking of network performance and network optimisation to meet the growing need for more coverage and capacity.

2. Network deployment. The job involves installation, commissioning and integration of telecom infrastructure components. Apart from technical knowledge of products, this function provides an opportunity to learn how to manage projects and teams.

3. Network operation and maintenance. Any telecom infrastructure cannot perform at its optimal capacity until it is given the best operational support and maintenance. The job of the operations and maintenance engineers is to monitor, troubleshoot and analyse the operations of the deployed telecom network.

4. Equipment testing. This involves testing of telecom equipment like base stations, transmission equipment and core network equipment.

5. Value-added services. This involves integration of new-age services like mobile commerce, entertainment, IPTV, gaming and multimedia into the core telecom network.

What the industry demands

A fresh graduate is likely to be offered the role of a base transceiver station engineer, drive test engineer, RF engineer, operations and maintenance engineer, switch engineer, GNOC engineer, etc. Usually, these jobs require a lot of travel depending upon the requirements of projects and vendors. Companies prefer candidates who have practical knowledge and are ready to be deployed in various functions. Hence those who have undergone some training or internship programme and have hands-on exposure are preferred. ●

The author is an assistant editor at EPY